

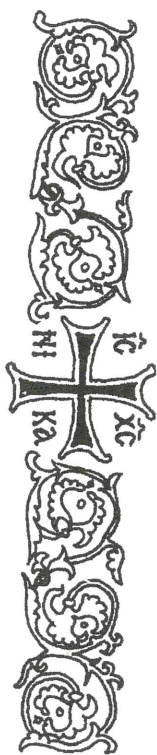


Work of Victor, 1660. Church of the Holy Unmercenaries, Naxos.

Christ the High Priest

I am that bread of life. Your fathers did eat manna in the wilderness, and are dead. This is the bread which cometh down from heaven, that a man may eat thereof and not die.

Jn. 6:48-50



PART THREE

OBJECTIONS - CLARIFICATIONS

OBJECTION 1

There are some pious men who, when they see a Christian communing frequently, and since they do not know the Scriptures, prevent him and reproach him. They tell him that frequent Communion is reserved for priests, and say: "If you want to commune frequently, then become a priest."

To such people we reply, not with our own words, but with the words of the Holy Scriptures, the sacred Councils, and the Saints and teachers of the Church. The priests' dignity is for them, as instruments, to offer and sanctify the divine Gifts through the descent of the Holy Spirit, and to intercede with God on behalf of the people. And there are other sacred rites which those who are not ordained cannot perform. I mean to say that, during Communion, when they receive the Mysteries, priests do not differ in any way from the laity or from monastics, except in this: that the priests impart Communion, while the laity receive it. And the priests receive Communion within the sanctuary, and directly, without the use of the sacred spoon, while the laity

and monastics receive Communion outside of the sanctuary, and indirectly, from the sacred spoon.

That priests do not differ at all from the laity in regards to Communion, we have as a witness the divine Chrysostom, who says,

One Father begat us. We are all of the same birth pangs (that is, born from the same mother, the baptismal font). The same drink has been given to all, or rather, not only has the same drink been given, but also to drink from one Cup. For the Father, desiring to lead us to a kindly affection, has also devised this, that we should drink out of one Cup, which is a sign of extreme love.¹²⁷

And elsewhere he says:

But there are occasions on which there is no difference at all between the priest and those under him, for instance, when we are to partake of the dread Mysteries. For we are all alike deemed worthy of them, not as under the Old Covenant, when the priest ate some things and those under him other things, and it was not lawful for the people to partake of those things of which the priest partook. It is not so now, but one body and one Cup are set before all.¹²⁸

Symeon of Thessaloniki says: "Communion is prepared for all of the faithful, and not just for the hierarch. Rather, the hierarch (or the priest) is to consecrate the all-holy body and blood of Christ and impart Communion to all of the faithful. All is done for the sake of Communion."¹²⁹

¹²⁷ *On Matthew* 32.7, PG 57, 386; NPNF (VI-10), 212-213.

¹²⁸ *On 2 Corinthians* 18.3, PG 61, 527; NPNF (VI-12), 365-366.

¹²⁹ Cf. *De Sacra Liturgia*, ch. 99, PG 155, 300B.

Job the Sinner, in the work *On the Mysteries*, says: "The aim, purpose, and work (of the Divine Liturgy) is to partake of the life-giving, dread, and sanctified Mysteries. Wherefore, they are first given within the sanctuary to those who are ordained, and then they are given to the prepared faithful, who are without."¹³⁰

It necessarily follows, then, that priests who liturgize must be the first to be prepared to commune, for they are the ones who make the offering. And then the people must be prepared, according to the Hieromartyr Clement: "Let the bishop commune first, then the presbyters, and the deacons, and the subdeacons, and the readers, and the chanters, and the ascetics, and the deaconesses, and the virgins, and the widows, then the children, and then the rest of the faithful, according to order, with reverence and fear, without any disruptions."¹³¹

The aforementioned Job says further: "It is permissible for all alike to receive Communion daily, both priests and laity, men and children and the elderly, and every age and order of Christians."

Any priests who do not commune Christians who approach divine Communion with reverence and faith are judged as murderers by God, as it is written in the book of the Prophet Hosea: "The priests have hid the way, they have murdered the people of Shechem; for they have wrought iniquity among the people" (Hos. 6:9). That is, the priests have covered the way, and the will, and the commandments of God, rather than revealing them.

¹³⁰ See the *Synlogismation* of Chrysanthos of Jerusalem.

¹³¹ *Apostolic Constitutions*, bk. 8, ch. 13, SC 336, 208, 210; ANF (07), 490.

I am in wonder and am amazed if there really are such priests as this, who turn away those who approach the Mysteries — and who do not in the least consider that they are lying by their words. For these very same priests, towards the end of the Liturgy, call out with a loud voice inviting all of the faithful, saying: "With the fear of God, with faith, and with love, draw near." Namely, "Approach the Mysteries in order to partake of them." And then these very same ones deny their own words and turn away those who approach. I am at a loss to describe such disorder and confusion.

OBJECTION 2

Some object saying that we are supposed to commune only every forty days.

Those who raise this objection bring forward the testimony of the divine Chrysostom as a justification:

Why, then, do we fast for forty days? In the past, and especially at the time when Christ entrusted to us these Mysteries, many people approached without thought or preparation. Since the Fathers realized that it was harmful for a person to approach the Mysteries in this heedless fashion, they came together and marked out forty days for people to fast, pray, and gather together to hear the word of God. Their purpose was that we might all scrupulously purify ourselves during this time by our prayers, almsgiving, fasting, vigils, tears, confession, and

all the other pious practices, so that we might approach the Mysteries with our consciences purified as much as possible.¹³²

To such people we reply that those who desire to support their arguments are accustomed to bringing forward sayings from the Holy Scripture or from one of the Saints, so that their hook may not be without bait, as the divine John Chrysostom says: "When a lie wishes to be convincing and to appear as true, it will not be believed if it does not first have a basis which appears as true."¹³³ This is exactly how these blessed people argue.

But one should not break and cut off the words of the divine Scripture, separating them from their context, and then use them in a twisted manner for his own purpose. For the divine Chrysostom also says,

We must not just examine the saying in and of itself, but we must consider everything that follows it; for whom, by whom, and to whom it was said; and why, when, and how it was said. It is not sufficient for someone to say: "It is written in the Scriptures," nor can one simply and haphazardly separate words and cut them off from the rest of the body of the God-inspired Scriptures and from their context, and, thus receiving them barren and stripped from their relevant surroundings, boldly

¹³² *Adversus Iudaeos* 3, 4, PG 48, 867.

¹³³ Translator's note: This quote is actually from Bishop Severianos of Gabala (*De Mundi Creatione* 2, 4, PG 56, 444). It is found among the works of Chrysostom (see PG 56, 429-430 nn). St. John of Damaskos quotes this exact saying in his *Parallela Rupesculmina* (700, 4, PG 96, 541A-541B), attributing it to Severianos.

misconstrue them. In this way many corrupt dogmas of the devil have entered into our life, for the devil convinces the more careless to quote isolated sayings of the Holy Scriptures, or to add to or subtract from the Scriptures, thus hiding the truth.¹³⁴

It is for this reason that the objectors should not only say that "Chrysostom says" that the divine Fathers established the practice of fasting for forty days, and after that communing. On the contrary, they also must consider what precedes and what follows the passage in question, to see what the divine Father says in the same homily, and for what reason and to whom he preached it. For, in accordance with their assertions, they must also say that the divine Chrysostom made Holy Communion available only on the day of Pascha. If these "defenders of the forty days" wish to establish such a practice, they must, according to their own opinion, either commune only one time a year, that is, on the day of Pascha, and thus be like those people of whom the divine Chrysostom speaks; or they must have ten Lents a year, according to the number of times they are accustomed to commune.

If they do not agree to the first, and cannot succeed in the second, let them be silent and not criticize and misrepresent the divine Chrysostom. For they make him out to be opposed not only to the Apostles, the Ecumenical and Local Councils, and many other Godbearing Fathers who refer to frequent Communion, but also to himself, inasmuch as he writes more than the others concerning frequent Communion, in many of his homilies, including the one in question:

So do not keep pleading this excuse, but show me that

¹³⁴ *In illud: Domine, non est in Homine 2, PG 56, 156.*

Christ did command us to do this. I am showing you quite the opposite. I am showing you that Christ not only did not command us to observe days but also even freed us from the obligation to do so. Hear what Paul had to say. And when I say Paul, I mean Christ; for it is Christ who moved Paul's soul to speak. What, then, did Paul say?

"Ye observe days, and months, and times, and years. I am afraid of you, lest I have bestowed upon you labour in vain" (Gal. 4:10-11). And again: "For as often as ye eat this bread, and drink this cup, ye do shew the Lord's death" (1 Cor. 11:26). When he said: "As often as," Paul gave the right and power to decide this to those who approach the Mysteries, and freed them from any obligation to observe days. Now our Pascha and Lent are not one and the same thing: the Pascha is one thing, Lent another. For Great Lent occurs but once a year. But we celebrate Pascha three times a week or even four. Or, to say it better, as often as we like. For Pascha does not consist of fasting, but of the Offering and Sacrifice which takes place during the daily gathering at the Liturgy. And as testimony that this is true, listen to Paul, who says: "Christ our passover (pascha) is sacrificed for us" (1 Cor. 5:7). . . . Therefore, as often as you partake of Communion with a pure conscience, you celebrate Pascha; not when you fast, but when you partake of that Sacrifice. . . . The catechumens never celebrates Pascha, even though he may fast every year during Lent, because he does not commune in the Offering. So then, even the person who did not fast, if he approaches with a pure conscience, celebrates Pascha, be it today, tomorrow, or any time he

partakes of Communion. For good and proper preparation for Communion is not judged by lengths of time, but by a pure conscience.

Yet we do just the opposite. We fail to cleanse our mind and, even though we are burdened with ten thousand sins, we consider ourselves to have celebrated Pascha if we approached the Mysteries on that day. But this is certainly not the case. If you approach the altar on the very day of the Great and Holy Sabbath with an evil conscience, you fail to share in Communion and you leave without celebrating Pascha. But if you wash away your sins and commune today, you truly celebrate Pascha.

Therefore you must safeguard this exactness and vigor of spirit, not in the observance of the proper times but in your approaching the altar. Now you would elect to endure all things rather than change this custom. But rather, in like manner, you must disdain it and choose to do or suffer anything so as not to approach the Mysteries when you are burdened with sins.... You have grounds for shame if you do not change for the better but persist in your untimely contentiousness. That is what destroyed the Jews. While they were always wanting the old customs and life, these were stripped from them and they turned to impiety.¹³⁵

And again St. Chrysostom says:

I know that many of us, because of the custom of doing so during the Feast, will approach the divine Table. You must, however, as I have said so many times, not receive Communion just because of a certain Feast; but you must

¹³⁵ *Adversus Iudeos* 3.4-5, PG 48, 866-869.

purify your conscience and then partake of the divine Table. For the sinner and unclean person is not worthy even during a Feast to partake of that holy and dread flesh. But the one who has washed away his sins through true repentance is clean, both during the Feast and at all times, and he is always worthy to partake of the divine Mysteries and enjoy the gifts and graces of God. I do not know why, but many overlook this. Such people, even if they are full of many sins, when they see that a Feast has arrived, rush because of the particular day and receive the sacred Mysteries, which they are not worthy even to look upon.¹³⁶

Behold, then, that the divine Chrysostom not only clearly confirms his purpose and opinion to those who love to hear the truth, but also prophetically overturns that custom now observed by many, of communing only every forty days.

If one wanted to address the forty days, he would certainly report how extensive would be a catalogue of all that the divine Fathers wrote. We, however, will bring forth just a few things, so that the uncertain may be assured.

At the time of the Holy First Ecumenical Council, the Christians of Asia celebrated Pascha together with the Jews. As an excuse, they claimed that they had received this practice from John the Theologian and the Apostle Philip, and some others. Even though many divine Fathers of various Local Councils wrote to them many times concerning this, they did not desist from their custom until the First Council convened. Among other things, this Council decreed that no one was any longer to celebrate Pascha with the

¹³⁶ *De Baptismo Christi* 4, PG 49, 369-370.

Jews, but on the Sunday after the vernal equinox, so it would not fall on the same day as the Jewish Passover. Yet some persisted in their bad custom, and it is such people that the divine Chrysostom addressed his homily, reproving them for disregarding so many divine Fathers simply on account of bad custom.

For this reason he praises the dignity of the divine Fathers of the First Council and attributes to them the defining of Lent. He says that they established Lent, wanting to convince his hearers and bring them to obedience. For someone might not know that the fast of Holy Lent was established by the Holy Apostles, who say in their sixty-ninth Canon: "If a bishop, or presbyter, or deacon, or subdeacon, or reader, or chanter does not fast during Holy and Great Lent, or on Wednesdays and Fridays throughout the year, let him be deposed; if he is a layman, let him be excommunicated."¹³⁷

Or, as St. Chrysostom says in another place, perhaps the Fathers of the First Council established Lent as it is known today, inasmuch as they added to it the Great and Holy Week of the Passion, for the following reason: "For this reason the Fathers lengthened the time of the fast, to give us time for repentance, and thus being purified to receive Communion."¹³⁸

But the main reason the First Ecumenical Council established Lent, says the divine Chrysostom, appears to be the following. Since Christians of that time were negligent and some did not fast at all during Holy Lent, while some fasted for only three weeks, others fasted for six weeks, while still

¹³⁷ *Pedalion*, 91; *The Rudder*, 122.

¹³⁸ *In illud: Vidi Dominum* 6.3, SC 277, 218.

others did something else, each according to his local custom (as Socrates attests in his *Ecclesiastical History*),¹³⁹ the Fathers of the First Ecumenical Council renewed the Canon of the Holy Apostles and established that all were without fail to fast for the entirety of Lent. The divine Chrysostom says that it was for the sake of this renewal that the Fathers formally delineated Lent, setting it down in writing.¹⁴⁰

These objectors set up the divine Chrysostom as a defender of their forty-day custom. But since he himself tears down their ideas like a spider web, we will be silent and proceed to the other objections.

OBJECTION 3

Some object saying that the purpose of frequent Communion, according to the Fathers, is that we not completely spurn the Communion of the divine Mysteries, and that, if some people commune infrequently on account of their great fear and piety, approaching the Mysteries with greater reverence, they partake worthily.

We would ask the people who say these things to show us whence and from which witnesses they learned the intent of Christ and the Saints. Perhaps they ascended into the heavens like Paul and heard these things?¹⁴¹ But Paul heard

¹³⁹ Cf. Book 5, ch. 22, PG 67, 625B-645A; NPNF (V2-02), 130-134.

¹⁴⁰ Cf. *Adversus Iudaeos* 3.4, PG 48, 867.

¹⁴¹ Cf. 2 Cor. 12:2-4.

"unutterable utterances," which a man cannot repeat. So how are they able to repeat them? If they learned them from somewhere else, how is it that they are not found written in the books of our divine Fathers? If indeed they are written there, and we have not found them, we ask them please to show them to us.

In any case, the fear they claim should attend the reception of the Mysteries is not of God, as the Prophet says: "There have they feared with fear where no fear is" (Ps. 52:6). For fear should attend transgression of the commandments, but not compliant submission and obedience. And neither is their piety true, but rather fake and hypocritical, because true piety reverences the words and commandments of the Lord and does not violate them. And they say these things, not in order to make Christians more cautious and reverent when it comes to Communion, but in order to discourage them and cut them off completely from it, and so bring them spiritual death.

For this reason, the divine Cyril of Alexandria replies to such supposedly pious people saying:

And if we long for eternal life, if we pray to have the Giver of immortality in ourselves, let us neither like some of the more heedless refuse to be blessed (by not communing of the Mysteries, that is), nor let the devil who is deep in wickedness lay a perilous piety (towards the divine Mysteries) as a trap and snare for us. What do you reply to us? "Paul writes: 'For he that eateth and drinketh unworthily, eateth and drinketh damnation to himself' (1 Cor. 11:29). And I, having examined myself, see that I am not worthy." And so we reply to you: When then will you be worthy? When will you present yourself to

Christ? For, if you are always going to be scared away by your mistakes, consider that, being human, you will never cease from making them ("As for transgressions, who can understand them?" [Ps. 18:12], says the Holy Psalmist), and you will be found completely without participation in that soul-saving sanctification (of the Mysteries).

Decide then to lead a holier life, in harmony with the law and the commandments of God, and so partake of the blessing (of Communion), believing that it has power to expel, not only death, but also our illnesses. For Christ thus coming to be in us lulls the law which rages in the members of our flesh, kindles piety towards God, and mortifies the passions, not imputing to us the transgressions in which we lie, but rather healing us as ones sick. For, being the Good Shepherd that He is, He binds up the broken, He raises the fallen, and He lays down His life for His sheep.¹⁴²

And again St. Cyril says:

The holy body of Christ then gives life to those who have it within them, and holds them together unto incorruption, being commingled with their bodies. For it is to be conceived of as the body of none other but Him Who is by nature life, having in itself the whole power of the united Word, and having the quality of, or rather fulfilled with, His effectuating energy, through which all things are given life and maintained in existence. But since all of this is so, let them who have now been baptized and have tasted the divine grace know that, if

¹⁴² *In Joannis Evangelium* 4.2, PG 73, 584D–585A.

they go sluggishly or leisurely to Church and for a long time keep away from the blessing (of the Eucharist) through Christ, and put on a pernicious piety in that they will not mystically partake of Him, they exclude themselves from eternal life, in that they decline to be given life. And this their refusal, albeit perhaps seeming to be the fruit of piety, becomes a snare and a scandal. For they should rather labor with all of their strength and eagerness so that they may be resolute in clearing away sin, and should take care to live a life most comely, and so hasten with all boldness to partake of life.... For thus, thus shall we overcome the deceit of the devil and, having become "partakers of the Divine Nature" (2 Pet. 1:4), mount upward to life and incorruption.¹⁴³

John Zonaras, in his interpretation of the second Canon of the Council in Antioch, says:

The Fathers use the word "shun" in this Canon, not to refer to cases in which someone actually hates Holy Communion, and for this reason does not commune, but rather to refer to the avoidance of Communion on account of supposed piety and humility. For if one were to actually spurn and avoid Holy Communion out of hate for it and as abhorring it, he would be condemned not only with excommunication but also with complete banishment and anathema.¹⁴⁴

The divine Cyril and John Zonaras sufficiently rebuke the supposed piety of those who are negligent, a piety which does not bear beneficial and salvific fruit. On the contrary,

¹⁴³ Ibid., 3.6, PG 73, 520D-521C.

¹⁴⁴ PG 137, 1284A-1284B.

this piety brings about death to the soul and total deprivation of eternal life. And eternal life is brought about through the frequent Communion of the divine Mysteries. All who are truly pious do not disregard the words of the Lord and the sacred Canons of the Apostles, Councils, and Saints, nor even think of doing so, fearing the judgment and condemnation that attend upon disobedience. Concerning these truly pious people, the Holy Spirit says through the Prophet Isaiah, "To such a man will I look, even to him that is meek, and humble, and peaceful, and trembleth at My words" (Is. 66:2).

OBJECTION 4

Some again put forth this opinion saying: "Look at the Righteous Mary of Egypt and many other hermits and ascetics who communed one time in their entire lives. This infrequency of partaking of Communion did not prevent them from being sanctified."

To these people we reply that hermits do not govern the Church, nor did the Church write the Canons for hermits, as the Apostle says: "The law is not made for a righteous man" (1 Tim. 1:9). And the divine Chrysostom adds:

All those who had zeal for the philosophy and way of life of the New Covenant of the Gospel did not live this life on account of the fear of hell, or because they were threatened, or on account of punishment, but only on account of divine love and fervent desire for God. For

they needed neither commands nor commandments and laws to urge them to love virtue and hate evil. But as noble children and free people, since they knew the nobility of their nature, and without any sort of fear and punishment, they rushed towards virtue on their own accord.¹⁴⁵

However, these same hermits, if they had the means to commune but did not, are also condemned as transgressors of the sacred Canons, and as disdainers of the divine Mysteries. But if they did not have the means to commune they are innocent, as the sacred Cabasilas says:

If then those living souls are ready and prepared for the Mystery, and if the Lord Who sanctifies and perfects wishes to sanctify, and desires to continue to give Himself, what can prevent such a communion? Certainly nothing. Then, someone will say, if someone among the living has the aforementioned good qualities in his soul, but does not approach the Mysteries, will he nevertheless receive the sanctification which they give? Not everyone, but only if someone cannot physically approach, as it is for the souls of the dead, and as it was the case for those who lived in the deserts, and in the mountains, and in caves, and in holes in the earth, who were not near any altar and Church, nor was it possible for them to see a priest. Christ Himself invisibly sanctified them with this sanctification (of the Mysteries). We know this because they had life, which they could not have had without partaking of the Mystery, for Christ Himself said: "Except ye eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink His blood,

¹⁴⁵ *De Verbis Apostoli, Habentes Eundem Spiritum* 1,6, PG 51, 286.

ye have no life in you" (Jn. 6:53). Another proof is the fact that God sent angels to several of these men with the Mystery. If, however, someone is able to approach the Table, but does not, it is impossible for him to receive the sanctification which they bring; not just because he did not approach, but, being able, he did not. And for this reason it shows that his soul is void of the good qualities required for the Mysteries. For what desire and eagerness for the Table does he possess who could easily come to it but will not? And what faith in God has he who does not fear the Lord's threatening words concerning those who despise this banquet? How can someone believe that that person actually loves the Mysteries which, although he is able to receive them, does not? For this reason it is not then surprising that Christ should grant to those souls that have departed from their bodies, and which are not guilty of any such evil, a share in that Table.¹⁴⁶

OBJECTION 5

Some object saying that Holy Communion is something fearful. For this reason, a holy, angelic, and perfect life is required in order to commune.

That the Mystery of divine Communion is great and

¹⁴⁶ *Sacrae Liturgiae Interpretatio* 42, PG 150, 457D-460C; *A Commentary on the Divine Liturgy*, 97-98.

fearful, and that it requires a holy and pure life, no one doubts. For the mere word "holy" signifies a great deal. Only God is holy, for He has holiness by nature and not by acquisition. People who are deemed worthy of Holy Baptism receive holiness by participation in the Holy God. For this reason they are called holy ones (saints), because they received sanctification through the grace of the Holy Spirit in their rebirth from above. And furthermore, they are called holy because they partake of the holy body and blood of our Lord, always receiving sanctification from the divine Mysteries. And as much as they draw near to God by doing the Master's commandments, so much more are they sanctified, ascending towards perfection. On the contrary, as much as they distance themselves from God by neglecting the commandments, so much more are they deprived of sanctification and ruled by the passions, and so much more does evil increase in them. For evil is nothing other than deprivation of the good.¹⁴⁷

Therefore, it is not at all prohibited to call as many as have been deemed worthy of the rebirth of the Holy Spirit "saints" and "holy." And it follows that they are in no way prohibited from frequently communing in the divine Gifts, being holy children by the grace of the Holy God. For this reason, the divine Chrysostom says that the Holy Things must be given to those who are saints and holy ones, and not to the unclean and polluted. To show what makes the saints different, he says:

Let no sinner approach. However, I do not mean "no"

¹⁴⁷ Cf. Dionysius the Areopagite, *De Divinis Nominibus* 4.23 and 30, PG 3, 725C and 732B; *Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works*, 91, 94.

sinner, because I would thus preclude my self above all from approaching the divine Table. What I mean is that no one who is persistently a sinner (that is, unconfessed and unrepentant) is to approach. For I know that we are all subject to penances because of our sins, and that no one can boast that he has a pure heart. That we do not have a pure heart, however, is not what is evil, but that we do not approach the One Who is able to purify us.¹⁴⁸

Theodoret of Cyr says: "Of those who partake of the divine Mysteries, some partake as lambs, namely, those who are perfect in virtue; while others partake as goats, namely, those who have erased the stains of their sins through repentance."¹⁴⁹

Therefore, even though the divine Fathers ascribe frequent Communion only to the perfect, it is clear that they do not seek perfection from communicants, but amendment of life through repentance. For just as all people are not of one and the same age in this visible world, so also are people at various stages in the spiritual world of the Church, according to the Parable of the Sower.¹⁵⁰ The perfect man offers God one hundred, the intermediate sixty, and the novice thirty, each according to his ability, and no one is rejected by God because he does not offer the hundred. And if we really think about it, we will see that it is impossible for anyone

¹⁴⁸ *In illud: Vidi Dominum* 6.3, SC 277, 220.

¹⁴⁹ *Quaestiones in Exodum* 24, PG 80, 253B. [Translator's note: We read in the *Apostolic Constitutions*: "If any one be holy, let him draw near [to the Eucharist]; but if any one not be such, let him become so through repentance" (bk. 7, ch. 26, SC 336, 56; ANF [07], 470).]

¹⁵⁰ Cf. Mt. 13:8.

to arrive at perfection without frequent Communion of the Holy Mysteries, for without Communion love cannot be achieved; and, without love, obedience to the Master's commandments cannot be achieved either. For, as the wise Solomon says: "The beginning of wisdom is the most sincere desire for instruction, and concern for instruction is love of her, and love of her is the keeping of her laws, and giving heed to her laws is assurance of immortality, and immortality brings one near to God; so the desire for wisdom leads to the kingdom" (Wis. 6:17-20).

For this reason, the holy Abba Apollo, knowing that divine Communion is the perfection of divine love, numbers it with the commandment of love, saying that "upon these two commandments," namely, frequent Communion and love for one's neighbor, "hang the whole Law and the Prophets" (Mt. 22:40).¹⁵¹

¹⁵¹ Translator's note: This is demonstrated by the following words of Abba Apollo, found in Palladios' *Lausiac History*:

We must bow down to our brothers when they approach. For we are not bowing down to them, but to God, as it is said: "When you see your brother, you see the Lord your God." This we have learned from Abraham (cf. Gen. 18). When you receive the brethren, invite them to rest for awhile, for this is what we learn from Lot, who so invited the angels (cf. Gen. 19:3). Also, the monks must commune of the Mysteries every day, if this is possible. For he who distances himself from the Mysteries distances himself from God. But he who receives Communion frequently, takes in the Savior frequently. For that saving voice says: "He that eateth My flesh, and drinketh My blood, dwelleth in Me, and I in him" (Jn. 6:56). This, then, is profitable for monks: for them to continuously remember the saving passion, and for them to be ready every day through preparing themselves and making themselves worthy at all times to receive the Holy and

But why should we say all of this? Do the people who raise the present objection commune every forty days as being perfect, or as being sinners and imperfect? If they commune as being perfect, they should commune more frequently, according to their own argument. But, if they commune as being imperfect, they must commune more frequently in order to become perfect, as we have already said.

If an infant is unable to grow into a man without bodily food, how much more must the soul be unable to arrive at perfection without spiritual food? Those wise in the things of this world say that there are three things apparent in an infant: first, that which is nourished; second, that through which it is nourished; and third, that which nourishes. That which nourishes is the nourishing soul; that which is nourished is the living (ensouled) body; and that with which it is nourished is food.

This, says Gabriel of Philadelphia, is also seen in the spiritual rebirth: "There is the one nourished, namely, the baptized and reborn man; that by which he is nourished, which is the immaculate Mysteries; and that which is nourishing, that is, the divine grace which changes them into the body and blood of our Savior." For this reason, Basil the Great says: "He who has been reborn through Baptism must be nourished by partaking of the divine Mysteries."¹⁵²

heavenly Mysteries, for in this way we are deemed worthy also of the forgiveness of sins. (52, PG 34, 1148A-1148B)

Also look ahead to Objection 7 where St. Jerome reports an encounter with this same Abba Apollo.

¹⁵² *De Baptismo* 1.3, PG 31, 1573A; *Saint Basil: Ascetical Works*, 386.

But if, again, these objectors receive Communion as sinners, they should commune neither every forty days nor even once a year, as John Chrysostom says:

Just as he who has a pure conscience should commune every day, so the one who finds himself in sins and unrepentant should not commune even during a Feast. For if we commune unworthily, even if once a year, we are not liberated from our offenses. Rather, this condemns us all the more, because, even though we only commune once a year, we still, even then, do not commune as pure. For this reason I ask all of you not to receive the divine Mysteries haphazardly and just because it is a Feast.¹⁵³

And elsewhere he says:

For since the priests cannot know who are sinners, and who unworthily partake of the Holy Mysteries, God often... delivers such people to Satan. For when diseases, attacks, sorrows, calamities, and the like afflict them, it is on this account. This is shown by Paul, who says: "For this cause many are weak and sickly among you, and many sleep" (1 Cor. 11:30). "But how can this be," someone says, "when we approach but once a year?" This is what is terrible, that you determine the worthiness of your approach, not by the purity of your mind, but by intervals of time. You think it is pious not to commune frequently, not knowing that you are scared by partaking unworthily even if just one time. But to receive worthily, even if

¹⁵³ *De Beato Philogonio* 4, PG 48, 755. [Translator's note: St. John continues:

"But whoever intends to partake of this Holy Offering, let him purify himself many days beforehand through repentance and prayer and almsgiving."]

frequently, is salvific. It is not bold to commune frequently, but to receive unworthily, even if one receives unworthily but once in his whole life. But we are so miserably foolish, that, though we commit thousands of evils in the course of a year, we are not anxious to be absolved of them, but are satisfied that we do not boldly and frequently dare to insult the body of Christ, not remembering that those who crucified Christ, crucified Him but once. Is the sin then the less, because committed but once? And Judas betrayed his Master but once. What then, did that exempt him from punishment? Why indeed is time to be considered in this matter? Let our hour of approaching the Mysteries be when our conscience is pure.¹⁵⁴

Again the divine Chrysostom says:

What then? Whom shall we approve, those who receive Communion once a year? Those who receive many times? Those who receive a few times? Neither those who receive once, nor those who receive often, nor those who receive seldom, but those who come with a pure conscience, with a pure heart, and with an irreproachable life. Let such always draw near, but those who are not such, let them not approach even once. "Why?", you will ask. Because they thus receive to themselves judgment, condemnation, punishment, and vengeance.¹⁵⁵

However (and I do not know why), those blessed people do not heed these things, and seek from those who would commune an angelic life and state. Now, that everyone who has been baptized and reborn through Holy Baptism has

¹⁵⁴ *On 1 Timothy* 5:3, PG 62, 529; NPNF [VI-13], 425.

¹⁵⁵ *On Hebrews* 17:4, PG 63, 131-132; NPNF [VI-14], 449.

promised to live an angelic life is obvious. For the Christian, just as he is commanded to do, pushes himself to fulfill the Master's commandments as much as possible, and this is what is proper to the angelic orders: to always fulfill and perfect the divine commands.

So, then, in this way, those who have been baptized and keep the divine commandments are not far from the manner of life [*politeia*] of the angels, inasmuch as they take care to preserve in their body the purity of the bodiless powers, as the Apostle cries out: "Our citizenship [*politeuma*] is in heaven" (Phil. 3:20). And the divine Chrysostom says: "Let us then draw to us the invincible aid of the Spirit, keeping the commandments, and we will by no means be inferior to the angels."¹⁵⁶ And again he says: "The baptized and saved Christian receives a double grace. First, in that he is given life by the grace of the Holy Spirit; and, second, in that he becomes like a light bird, and flies freely to the heavens, living with the angels."¹⁵⁷